ENGLISH COMPILATION 11TH

Hornbill

English Core - Complete Study Guide

Prose & Poetry

Comprehensive Summaries, Themes &

Important Questions with Answers

Written & Compiled by
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Complete Chapter-wise Guide for Examination Preparation

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Complete Study Guide

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Content Includes:

Complete Chapter Summaries

Themes & Character Analysis

Important Questions with Answers

Literary Devices & Explanations

Extract-Based Questions

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SECTION A: PROSE

Complete Chapter Summaries, Themes & Important Questions

Chapter 1: The Portrait of a Lady

By Khushwant Singh

Summary

"The Portrait of a Lady" is a personal tale of the author's grandmother. Singh recounts his memories of his grandmother, who was an elderly woman during his childhood and how their relationship evolved over the years. He describes her daily routines and how she matured as a person, providing details of her physical appearance to help readers form a mental image of her.

Themes

The themes in the story cover various phases of the author's life:

- **Childhood:** Innocence, fondness, and the affectionate bond between grandmother and grandson
- **City Life:** Disconnection and unfamiliarity in their relationship
- **Return from Abroad:** Reunion, marked by a poignant and bittersweet conclusion

Physical Appearance of Grandmother

The writer remembers his grandmother as being short and healthy, with a slight bend in her posture. Her silver hair was messy and scattered across her wrinkled face. She would walk around the house in white clothing, holding one hand on her waist and the other to her rosary beads. Although the writer didn't consider her to be conventionally beautiful, he found her to be consistently lovely. He compares her serene expression to that of a winter landscape.

Village Life

During their time in the village, she would wake him up in the morning, prepare his breakfast, and send him to school, which was connected to the temple. While the children were learning the alphabet, she would sit inside and study sacred texts. On their trips back home, she would give the leftover chapattis to the street dogs.

City Life and Growing Distance

Their relationship took a turn when they moved to the city. Although they still shared a room, they began to grow apart. The writer now attended a city school and took classes in subjects like English, Physics, Mathematics, and others that his grandmother was not familiar with. She could no longer accompany him to school as she used to, and felt sad that there was no teaching about God and scriptures at the city school. Instead, he was given music lessons, but she remained silent about it. She believed that music was only fit for prostitutes and beggars, not for gentlemen.

College Years and Loneliness

When the writer went to college, he got his own room, breaking the close bond between him and his grandmother. She became increasingly isolated and rarely talked to anyone in the house. She accepted her loneliness, spending most of her time at her spinning wheel, praying, and reciting prayers. In the afternoons, she would break bread into pieces and feed the birds, which would perch on her legs, head, and shoulders.

Farewell and Return

When the writer was leaving for further studies abroad, his grandmother didn't show any distress. She came to the train station to say goodbye, but remained silent, only kissing his forehead and praying. The writer thought that this might be their last goodbye, but after five years, she was still there to welcome him home when he returned, joyfully celebrating his return.

Grandmother's Death

The morning after her grandson's return, she became ill. Despite the doctor saying it was just a mild fever and would pass quickly, she knew that her time on earth was limited. She chose to spend her remaining moments in prayer, reciting the beads on her rosary. She passed away while praying in bed, her rosary falling from her hand as her lips stopped moving. When her body was found wrapped in a red shawl, thousands of sparrows came to mourn her passing, sitting quietly around her body. When her body was taken for the final rites, all the sparrows flew away without a sound.

Conclusion

The Portrait of a Lady highlights the strong and loving bond between the writer and his grandmother. The story serves as an example of how close and beautiful the relationship between a grandson and grandmother can be.

Important Questions & Answers

Q1. How does Khushwant Singh describe his old grandmother?

Ans: The author describes his grandmother as short, fat, and slightly bent. Her face was a criss-cross of wrinkles. She had silver hair that was scattered across her pale, puckered face. She always wore white clothes and held a rosary in her hands.

Q2. Give a pen-picture of the narrator's grandfather as he appeared in the portrait.

Ans: The grandfather in the portrait wore a big turban and loose-fitting clothes. His long, white beard covered the best part of his chest, and he looked at least a hundred years old.

Q3. Why did the narrator's grandmother give the impression of 'winter landscape in the mountains'?

Ans: The grandmother's serene expression, white clothes, and peaceful demeanor reminded the author of the calm, quiet, and peaceful winter landscape in the mountains.

Q4. How can you say that the grandmother was a deeply religious-minded lady?

Ans: The grandmother was deeply religious. She constantly recited prayers and counted her rosary beads. She read scriptures at the temple, and in her last moments, she was praying with her rosary.

Q5. "My grandmother and I were good friends." When was the friendship cemented and broken?

Ans: The friendship was cemented during their village life when she would wake him up, get him ready for school, and walk with him. It was broken when they moved to the city and the author went to college, getting his own room.

Q6. What made the grandmother unhappy in the city?

Ans: The grandmother was unhappy in the city because she could not accompany the author to school. She was also upset that the city school did not teach about God and scriptures, and instead gave music lessons which she considered inappropriate.

Q7. What was the grandmother's attitude towards English education and music lessons at school?

Ans: She was unhappy about English education as it did not include teachings about God. She was silent about music lessons but believed that music was fit only for prostitutes and beggars, not for gentlemen.

Q8. How did the sparrows mourn the grandmother's death?

Ans: Thousands of sparrows gathered quietly around her body. They did not chirp or eat the breadcrumbs thrown for them. When her body was taken for cremation, they flew away silently.

Chapter 2: We're Not Afraid to Die... If We Can All Be Together

By Gordon Cook & Alan East

Summary

In 1976, Gordon Cook, his wife Mary, his son Jonathan, and daughter Suzanne, along with two sailors, Larry Vigil (American) and Herb Sailor (Swiss), planned a voyage around the world. They got a ship named the Wavewalker which was 23 meters long and weighed 30 tons with a wooden hull. The story narrates their epic struggle for survival against the fury of nature.

The Voyage Begins

The initial part of the journey, covering approximately 105,000 kilometers to Cape Town, went smoothly. However, during their second trip to Cape Town, they encountered strong windstorms and waves that were as high as the mainmast, reaching up to 15 meters. Despite these challenges, the narrator was not discouraged. On December 25th, they arrived in the Southern Indian Sea, about 3,500 kilometers east of Cape Town, and celebrated Christmas together.

The Disaster Strikes

On January 2nd, the waves became massive in size, causing the sailors to slow down the boat's speed, lower the storm jib, and take precautions to ensure their safety. The sailors even conducted a life-raft drill and secured the life-boats and life jackets. Suddenly, at 6 pm, a massive explosion rocked the Wavewalker and the narrator was thrown off from the ship. He could see his death and started losing consciousness but another huge wave hit it and righted it. The narrator was thrown back onto the deck and sustained head and rib injuries from hitting the walls of the Wavewalker.

The Struggle for Survival

Despite his injuries, the narrator took control of the situation and decided to handle it on his own. Meanwhile, Larry and Herb started pumping out water from the ship. Despite the challenges, the narrator managed to cover the gaps with canvas to prevent water from entering the ship. However, the hand pumps failed and the electric pumps short-circuited at the same time. Fortunately, the narrator found a working spare electrical pump. The entire night, they all worked together, pumping, steering, repairing, and sending out radio signals for help.

Hope and Rescue

After checking the charts, the narrator realized that their last hope was the French scientific base on ILE Amsterdam Island. Sue and Jon were badly injured, but they were not afraid to die as long as they were together. Sue had a swollen head and a deep injury, but the narrator was determined to show courage for his children. Finally, they reached Ile Amsterdam and were greeted by the 28 inhabitants of the volcanic island.

Conclusion

The sailors' collective strength and never-say-die certainty allowed them to survive and emerge from the jaws of death. The story demonstrates the power of unity, courage, and optimism in the face of dire circumstances.

Important Questions & Answers

Q1. List the steps taken by the captain to protect the ship when rough weather began.

Ans: The captain slowed down the boat, dropped the storm jib, formed a loop with thick mooring rope across the stem, completed life-raft drill, fastened lifelines, and made everyone wear life jackets and waterproof clothing.

Q2. Describe the mental condition of the voyagers on 4th and 5th January.

Ans: On January 4th, they were hopeful but anxious. On January 5th, they were near despair but still fighting. The children showed remarkable courage, with Jonathan saying he wasn't afraid to die if they were all together.

Q3. Describe the shifts in the narration of the events as indicated in the three sections of the text.

Ans: Section 1: Preparations and smooth beginning; Section 2: The disaster and struggle; Section 3: Survival and rescue.

Q4. What difference did you notice between the reaction of the adults and the children when faced with danger?

Ans: The adults were worried and anxious, while the children showed remarkable courage. Jonathan said he wasn't afraid to die if they were together, which gave the narrator strength to fight.

Q5. Give a brief description of the narrator's boat. How had the narrator equipped and tested it?

Ans: The "Wavewalker" was a 23-meter long, 30-ton wooden-hulled ship. The narrator spent months preparing and testing it under the most adverse conditions before the voyage.

Q6. How does the story suggest that optimism helps to endure 'the direst stress'?

Ans: The narrator's optimism and determination to save his family kept him going despite severe injuries and impossible odds. The children's positive attitude also strengthened his resolve.

Q7. Explain the bravery of Jonathan.

Ans: Jonathan, only six years old, remained strong throughout the crisis. He said he wasn't scared to die and that if they were together, it would be easy to face death. His words motivated the narrator to do his best to save the family.

Chapter 3: Discovering Tut: The Saga Continues

By A.R. Williams

Summary

The story revolves around the mysterious life and death of Tutankhamun, the youngest ruler of ancient Egypt. The discovery of his tomb in 1922 by the renowned archaeologist Howard Carter led to various investigations, including X-rays and CT scans, which have shed light on his life and death.

Key Characters

- **King Tut:** The final heir of a prominent dynasty that dominated Egypt for centuries. His well-preserved body was the first to be scanned.
- **Howard Carter:** British archaeologist who discovered King Tut's tomb in 1922.
- **Zahi Hawass:** Secretary General of Egypt's Supreme Council of Antiquities, conducted the CT scan.
- **Amenhotep III:** Tutankhamun's father or grandfather, a highly influential ruler.
- **Akhenaten:** Tut's successor who sparked controversy by advocating worship of Aten.

The Mystery of King Tut

The mysterious death of Tutankhamun, the last ruler of the Pharaoh dynasty, has long been a topic of debate among historians and archaeologists. In 1922, the young ruler's tomb was uncovered by British archaeologist Howard Carter, and over 80 years later, a CT scan was conducted to shed light on the events surrounding his life and death through a forensic reconstruction.

The Dynasty and Religious Changes

Tutankhamun's father or grandfather, Amenhotep III, was a highly influential ruler who held power for almost 40 years. Tut's successor, Amenhotep IV, changed his name to Akhenaten and sparked a strange period in Egyptian history by shifting the religious capital from Thebes to Amarna and destroying the images and closing the temples of the major god, Amun. Tutankhamun became ruler after a short-lived reign by another mysterious ruler and ruled for 9 years.

The Discovery and Its Challenges

When Tut's mummified body was found, it was surrounded by a wealth of gold and treasures. After examining the treasures, Carter planned to investigate Tut's three nested boxes. Unfortunately, many of the items in the tomb had already been misplaced. Tutankhamun's tomb was discovered buried 26 feet beneath the ground and contained wall paintings. It is believed that he was interred in the months of March or April.

The Problem with the Resin

One of the coffins posed a challenge to Carter. The resin used to attach Tut's body to the bottom of the solid gold coffin was strong enough to make it difficult to remove. Carter attempted to soften the resin by exposing the box to the sun for several hours, but this method did not work. Eventually, Carter was forced to use a chisel and hammer to remove the adhesive. He feared that if he did not, the thieves would have stolen the gold and other treasures. His team first removed the head of the mummy and then systematically cut each joint. The body parts were placed on a layer of sand, placed in a wooden box, and returned to their original location.

The CT Scan

In January 2009, the mummy was taken for a CT scan, which uses multiple X-rays to create a 3D image. After the scan was completed, the workmen transferred the body back to its tomb. However, during the process of moving the body to the trailer holding the scanner, the device suddenly stopped working. The scan was eventually completed after a pair of spare fans were used, and the body was returned to its tomb where it now rests peacefully.

Conclusion

The Discovering Tut: The Saga Continues narrative highlights the life and legacy of Tutankhamun, who was a fearless ruler of the mighty Pharaoh Dynasty. Despite the mysteries surrounding his death, he now rests peacefully in his tomb.

Important Questions & Answers

Q1. Why and how were mummies preserved for thousands of years in Egypt?

Ans: Mummies were preserved using a process called mummification. The body was dried using natron salt, organs were removed and preserved separately, and the body was wrapped in linen bandages. They believed in afterlife and wanted to preserve the body for the journey after death.

Q2. What was the atmosphere like when King Tut was taken for a CT Scan?

Ans: The atmosphere was tense and filled with anticipation. The world's most famous mummy glided head first into the CT scanner. Tourists had been visiting the tomb all afternoon, and now scientists were hoping to solve the medical mysteries of this young ruler.

Q3. Why did Carter become unpopular among the Egyptians?

Ans: Carter became unpopular because he damaged King Tut's mummy while trying to remove it from the coffin. He had to cut the body into pieces to free it from the resin, which was considered disrespectful to the ancient ruler.

Q4. Why did King Tut's mummy have to undergo CT scan?

Ans: The CT scan was done to investigate the lingering medical mysteries about King Tut's life and death - his age at death and the manner of his death, which had been subjects of much speculation.

Q5. Who was Howard Carter? What was his discovery?

Ans: Howard Carter was a British archaeologist who discovered King Tut's tomb in 1922 after years of searching. The tomb was largely undamaged despite a past break-in.

Q6. What problem did Carter face when he reached the mummy of King Tut? How did he find a way out?

Ans: Carter faced the problem of hardened resin that had cemented the mummy to the coffin. When exposing it to the sun didn't work, he had to use chisels and hammers to cut the body free.

Q7. "Curse of the Pharaoh", joked a guard nervously. What is the curse and why did the guard say so?

Ans: The Pharaoh's curse was believed to bring death or misfortune to those who disturbed the tomb. The guard joked about it when the CT scan machine's fans became clogged with sand dust and stopped working.

Chapter 4: The Adventure

By Jayant Narlikar

Summary

"The Adventure" is a science fiction story about Professor Gaitonde who discovers a conflicting history and sets out on a journey to solve the mystery. He visits a library and discovers a new perspective on history, experiencing an alternate reality where the Marathas won the Battle of Panipat.

The Alternate Reality

Professor Gaitonde is a well-known historian traveling from Bombay to Pune, but finds himself in an alternate world where history has taken a different turn. He discovers that the East India Company still exists and the Maratha leader was saved in the Battle of Panipat, contrary to historical records. After a car crash, Gaitonde experiences this alternate reality in a coma.

The Different Bombay

The Mumbai he is in is completely different from the actual Mumbai. The Victoria Terminus Station where he gets down is very clean, coaches of train read 'Greater Bombay Metropolitan Railway'. Even the staff were Anglo-Indian with some British officials. Gaitonde noticed the East India Company Headquarters when he exited the train. Similar structures included banks and brands that were primarily British. In reality, the Forbes office where his son worked was not even there.

The Library Discovery

He went to the library to read about the Battle of Panipat in an attempt to solve the mystery. Reading reveals that the details differ from what actually occurred. In reality, he discovered through reading that India was never under British rule, which shocked him. Volume one took the history up to the period of Ashoka, volume two up to Samudragupta, volume three

up to Mohammad Ghori and volume four up to the death of Aurangzeb. Up to this period history was as he knew it. The change evidently had occurred in the last volume.

The Azad Maidan Incident

After going to the library, he went to the Azad Maidan and got into a brawl with some of the spectators there. Gaitonde was pushed off the stage and found unconscious in Azad Maidan after waking from his time-travelling nightmare.

Rajendra's Explanation

Rajendra Deshpande, Professor Gaitonde's friend, tries to explain his strange experience using Catastrophe Theory and the lack of determinism in Quantum Theory. He explains that according to Catastrophe Theory, a small change in circumstances can lead to a sudden shift in behavior. He applies this to the Battle of Panipat, where a missed bullet caused the Maratha army to lose morale and ultimately led to defeat. He believes that a small change in the situation could have changed the outcome of the war and favored the Marathas.

The Theory of Reality

He discovers during his visit that reality is different from what our senses may perceive. As a result, the world we inhabit might take on several forms or dimensions. Rajendra drew a parallel between the electrons orbiting the nucleus whose position cannot be predicted, to the transition made by Gangadharpant from one world to another. According to Rajendra, different realities exist, but the observer can experience only one of them at a time.

Conclusion

The Adventure teaches us that there are realities besides the ones we perceive, and while they may appear real, they are all simply imaginary. The story explores the fascinating concept of parallel universes and how small events can change the course of history.

Important Questions & Answers

Q1. What sort of 'Adventure' has been narrated by Jayant Narlikar?

Ans: Professor Gangadharpant's adventure wasn't tangible or real. He studied history and was interested in what would have happened if Marathas had won the Battle of Panipat. He visited the new Bombay during his two-day coma and had a traumatic experience on Azad Maidan.

Q2. What was Gangadhar Pant's experience on the way to Bombay?

Ans: Gangadhar Pant took the Jijamata express from Pune to Mumbai. At Sarhad station, an Anglo-Indian checked permits. The British Raj was established there. On the train, he was joined by Khan Sahib. He observed that the city was very different from what he had imagined.

Q3. What had Professor Gaitonde not expected in Bombay?

Ans: He had not expected to witness the dominance of the East India Company in Bombay. According to history texts, the company was dissolved after 1857, but it seemed to be alive and flourishing.

Q4. What bitter experience did the professor have at the meeting in Azad Maidan?

Ans: When he noticed the presidential chair was empty, he sat on it. The crowd objected, claiming the chair had symbolic meaning. The professor was violently escorted from the dais as soon as he started speaking.

Q5. How did Rajendra try to explain the mystery of reality?

Ans: Rajendra explained that our senses don't show us complete reality. Different realities exist, and the professor had made a transition from one world he knew to another that could have been.

Q6. How did Rajendra Deshpande apply his theory of catastrophic experience regarding the Battle of Panipat?

Ans: Rajendra applied Catastrophe Theory to explain that a small change - like a missed bullet - could have changed the outcome of the Battle of Panipat, leading to a completely different history.

Chapter 5: The Silk Road

By Nick Middleton

Summary

The Silk Road is a story about the author, Nick Middleton's journey to Mount Kailash through Tibet. The author wants to go to Mt. Kailash to finish his Kora (a sacred ritual for Hindus and Buddhists) because he wanted to develop positive thinking in his life.

The Journey Begins

The author took Daniel as his companion. They started their journey from slopes of Ravu. They had a driver named Tsetan who knew a route to Mount Kailash in the southwest direction. Lhamo, a local lady from Ravo, gifted the author a sheepskin coat - the general attire of drokbas.

The Tibetan Landscape

During their journey, the author observed wide, barren fields with gazelles eating the grass, a herd of wild asses called kyang and isolated drokbas taking care of their cattle and nomads' tents guarded by large Tibetan mastiffs that were highly valued as hunting dogs in imperial China.

The Tibetan Mastiffs

They passed nomads' dark tents pitched in splendid isolation, usually with a huge black dog, a Tibetan mastiff, standing guard. These beasts would cock their great big heads when they became aware of their approach and fix them in their sights. As they continued to draw closer, they would explode into action, speeding directly towards them, like a bullet from a gun and nearly as fast. These shaggy monsters, blacker than the darkest night, usually wore bright red collars and barked furiously with massive jaws.

Altitude Sickness

The group saw snow-covered mountains that were challenging to cross, and the author experienced headaches due to the altitude, which was 5,210 meters above sea level according to their watch. The cold weather also affected the author's physiological functions. Tired and hungry, he started breathing through his mouth. After a while, he switched to single-nostril power which seemed to be admitting enough oxygen but, just as he was drifting off, he woke up abruptly. Something was wrong. His chest felt strangely heavy.

The Town of Hor

Later in the day, they reached a town named Hor, which was described by the author as "miserable" with a lack of vegetation and surrounded by rocks and dust. Daniel returned to Lhasa, leaving the author feeling disappointed about the Mansoravar Lake, located near the town of Hor, which was filled with garbage. Hor is located on the east-west highway when one travels from Lhasa to Kashmir. It is a grim desolate place littered with accumulated refuse. There is no vegetation in this town.

Darchen and the Medical College

Later that night, they arrived at a guest house in Darchen, but the author was unable to sleep. The next morning, Tsetan took the author to the Darchen Medical College for evaluation. Upon being assured that the author was fit enough to do the kora, Tsetan returned to Lhasa. The next morning, the author woke up feeling refreshed and found Darchen to be not as bad as he initially thought. He described the town as dusty and run-down with a few basic shops.

Meeting Norbu

Not many pilgrims were around, and the author thought he might have arrived too early for the pilgrimage season. With most of the way blocked by snow, the author didn't want to do the kora alone. While waiting for the right conditions, the author met Norbu, a researcher from the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences in Beijing who was studying the significance of the kora in Buddhist literature. The author got to know Norbu and found out they were both there to do the pilgrimage. So, they decided to do it together, and the author felt his positive mindset was paying off.

Conclusion

The author concludes the story on a positive note, that being determined and dedicated toward one's goal will bring positive results in life. Despite the challenges that the author faced during his journey, he was able to find a partner who was as interested in kora as he, and both completed their pilgrimage together.

Important Questions & Answers

Q1. Why were Tibetan Mastiffs popular in China's imperial courts?

Ans: Tibetan Mastiffs were highly valued as hunting dogs in imperial China. They were completely fearless, had massive jaws, and would attack anything that approached their territory.

Q2. The author's experience at Hor was in stark contrast to earlier accounts of the place. Discuss.

Ans: Previous visitors had been awestruck by the magnificence of Mansarovar Lake, but the author found Hor shabby and unclean, with accumulated garbage and no vegetation.

Q3. How was Tsetan a big support to the author during the journey?

Ans: Tsetan was a skilled driver who knew the route to Mount Kailash. He drove carefully through dangerous terrain, took the author to the medical college when he was unwell, and waited until he was assured the author was fit for the kora.

Q4. "As a Buddhist, he told me, he knew that it didn't really matter if I passed away, but he thought it would be bad for business." What is the significance of this statement?

Ans: This shows Tsetan's practical nature. While his Buddhist beliefs made him accept death as natural, as a professional driver, he was concerned about the business implications if something happened to the author.

Q5. What do you understand about the term 'Kora' as used in the lesson?

Ans: Kora is a sacred ritual or pilgrimage performed by Hindus and Buddhists around holy sites, particularly Mount Kailash. It involves circumambulating the mountain as an act of devotion.

Q6. What was Norbu's importance for the writer?

Ans: Norbu was a researcher from Beijing who was also there to do the kora. He became the author's companion for the pilgrimage, solving the author's problem of having to do the kora alone.

SECTION B: POETRY

Complete Poem Summaries, Themes, Literary Devices & Questions

Poem 1: A Photograph

By Shirley Toulson

Summary

The poem is a tribute to the poet's mother. She is looking at an old photograph of her mother which has a frame of cardboard. The picture has three girls in which the middle one is the oldest and tallest. It is her mother when she was twelve years old or so. Beside her, on both sides are her two cousins, Betty and Dolly, who are holding her hands and are younger than her. They went for paddling on a beach holiday. Her uncle took the photograph then.

The Photograph's Memory

The poet could not help but notice her mother's sweet face. The sea touched her terribly transient feet which depicted that she changed over the years and the sea remained the same. After twenty-thirty years, her mother would laugh at the photograph. She would make the poet look at the photograph and tell her how their parents would dress them up for the beach holiday. The beach holiday was her mother's favourite past memories while her laugh was the poet's favourite memory. Both of them lost something which they cherished a lot and yet cannot live that moment again. Those sweet moments were memories now.

The Loss

Now, the poet's mother had been dead for the past twelve years, which is the same number as of her age when the photograph was taken back then. She cannot express the grief that she has from her mother's absence. The poem ends with the line "Its silence silences" - showing how the loss has left the poet speechless.

Word Meanings

Paddling: walking in shallow water **Transient:** short-term; temporary

Snapshot: photograph **Wry:** ironic; mocking

Laboured ease: oxymoron showing the difficulty of accepting loss

Literary Devices

- **Alliteration:** "Stood still", "Through their", "My mother's", "Terribly transient", "Silence silences"
- **Oxymoron:** "Laboured ease" - contradicting terms used together
- **Epithet:** "Terribly transient" - describing the fleeting nature of life
- **Contrast:** The unchanging sea vs. the changing/transient human life

Important Questions & Answers

Q1. The poet talks about a particular cardboard. How is it special to her?

Ans: The cardboard has her mother's seaside photo taped to it. The mother appeared to be having fun on her seaside holiday. She lost her mother a while ago, thus the picture holds a unique meaning for her because it both makes her joyful and sad to look at it.

Q2. What can you say about the childhood of the poet's mother?

Ans: The poet's mother must have had a happy and fun-filled upbringing. The picture of the seaside holiday makes this obvious. Even many years after the sea holiday, the poet's mother still chuckles when she looks at the photo.

Q3. What moment does the photograph depict?

Ans: The poet's mother and her two cousins Dolly and Betty are shown in the snapshot taken by the poet's uncle, enjoying a seaside holiday. They are all smiles in beautiful beach outfits.

Q4. Why does the poet feel nostalgic?

Ans: The poet comes across an old photo of her mother standing on the seashore with her cousins. When the poet's mother would see that old portrait, she used to giggle. Yet, time has gone, and the poet is now left with nothing but her mother's memories.

Q5. What does the poet say about her mother's face?

Ans: The poet observes that her mother had a lovely smile on her face and showed concern for her younger relatives. The poet adds that when her mother later saw the photo, she would laugh heartily.

Q6. "Its silence silences." Explain.

Ans: The silence of the photograph (representing the mother's death) has left the poet speechless. The loss is so profound that words cannot express it.

Poem 2: The Laburnum Top

By Ted Hughes

Summary

The poem starts with a description of the Laburnum tree whose top was still and silent. Its leaves had turned yellow and seeds had fallen down. It was daytime in the month of September when the tree was standing still and death-like. The life-less tree becomes alive by the arrival of the Goldfinch bird.

The Goldfinch's Arrival

She came to feed her younger ones who are on the thickness of the branch. The tree is her shelter. She arrives at the end of the branch with a chirping sound. She further moves to the other side of the branch with rapid and precautionary movement like a lizard. As soon as she arrives, her younger ones start chirping like a machine and vibrating and flapping their wings. The death-like tree becomes alive and it trembles and shakes.

The Departure

After feeding them, she flies to the other side of the branch. Her dark coloured face with the yellow body was barely visible as she vanished behind the yellow leaves. She flew away in the sky, leaving the tree death-like again.

Word Meanings

Laburnum: a short tree with hanging branches, yellow flowers, and poisonous seeds

Goldfinch: a small singing bird with yellow feathers on its wings

Twitching: sudden jerk movement

Chirrup: a bird making repeated high-pitched sounds

Startlement: feeling or showing sudden shock

Chitterings: to make a chattering sound **Trillings:** to produce a chirruping sound

Subsides: diminishes

Literary Devices

- **Alliteration:** "September sunlight", "tree trembles"
- **Simile:** "Sleek as a lizard" - comparing the bird's movement to a lizard
- **Metaphor:** "She enters the thickness, and a machine starts up" - comparing the noise of birds to a machine; "It is the engine of her family"
- **Personification:** "The whole tree trembles and thrills" - giving human qualities to the tree
- **Transferred Epithet:** "her barred face identity mask"

Important Questions & Answers

Q1. How does the Laburnum tree appear in September?

Ans: In September, the leaves turn yellow, the seeds fall on the ground. The tree is silent, still, and appears death-like in the afternoon sunshine.

Q2. Does the arrival of the goldfinch bring about a change in it?

Ans: Yes, the laburnum tree bursts into activity and life when the goldfinch arrives. There is plenty of sound and movement in its branches. The whole tree trembles and thrills.

Q3. Why did the goldfinch enter the thickness of the laburnum tree?

Ans: The goldfinch entered to feed her young ones. The lines "the engine of her family" and "she stokes it full" reflect this.

Q4. How is the tree transformed during the bird's visit?

Ans: The tree is silent, still and empty before and after the bird's visit. When the bird arrives, there is the sound of chirping, fluttering of wings and the whole tree comes alive.

Q5. In the poem 'Laburnum Top', what is the bird's movement compared to?

Ans: The bird's movement has been compared to that of a lizard. Her movement is smooth, sleek and clean like that of a lizard's.

Q6. Why is the image of the engine evoked by the poet?

Ans: When the goldfinch enters the dense leaf cover to feed her chicks, the poet uses the metaphor of an engine to depict the stirrings, sounds, and energy that can be heard.

Q7. What do you notice about the beginning and end of the poem?

Ans: The tree was silent before the goldfinch came. It became silent again after she left. This creates a circular structure showing the temporary nature of the tree's animation.

Poem 3: The Voice of the Rain

By Walt Whitman

Summary

In the poem, the poet asks the soft-falling shower, 'Who are you?' to which she replies that she is the poem of earth. It is a strange thing for the rain to reply to the poet. The rain told the poet that she cannot be touched as she rises in the form of water vapor in the sky from the land and the bottomless sea.

The Rain's Journey

It changes its shape yet it remains the same. The vapor changes into clouds due to condensation. It falls back on the surface of the earth to provide water to the drought-prone areas and to beautify and purify the earth (its birthplace). It provides life to the seeds inside the earth and helps them grow.

The Rain's Purpose

The rain doesn't care if anyone bothers about her deeds or not, she completes her work and comes back home. The poet also compares the rain with a song as they both share a common journey. The song originates from the heart of the singer, travels across to fulfill the aim and comes back with due love for the singer (its originator).

Word Meanings

Who art thou: Who are you **Eternal:** never-ending

Impalpable: which cannot be touched or described **Whence:** where

Vaguely: not clearly **Lave:** wash; bathe **Latent:** hidden/buried

Literary Devices

- **Personification:** The rain is given human qualities - it speaks and describes itself as "the Poem of Earth"
- **Metaphor:** "I am the Poem of Earth" - rain is compared to a poem
- **Hyperbole:** "Bottomless sea" - exaggerated statement
- **Imagery:** "Soft-falling shower" - visual description

Important Questions & Answers

Q1. There are two voices in the poem. Who do they belong to?

Ans: The two voices belong to the poet and the rain itself. The poet asks "Who art thou?" and the rain replies "I am the Poem of Earth."

Q2. What does the phrase 'strange to tell' mean?

Ans: It conveys the poet's wonder at the rain's capacity for communication. It is unusual for rain to speak and respond like a living being.

Q3. How does the rain justify its claim 'I am the Poem of Earth'?

Ans: Like a poem brings joy and life to its readers, rain brings life and beauty to Earth. Both have rhythm and purpose in their existence.

Q4. Describe the never-ending cycle of rain.

Ans: Water rises as vapor from land and sea, becomes clouds, transforms, and descends as rain to Earth. It gives life to seeds and returns to oceans through rivers, completing the cycle.

Q5. Why does the rain call itself 'impalpable'?

Ans: When water is in the form of vapor rising to the sky, it cannot be seen or touched. The process cannot be perceived by our senses, making it impalpable.

Q6. Why is rain essential for Earth?

Ans: Without rain, Earth would remain dry, droughts would develop, dust wouldn't be washed away, and seeds of plants would perish. Rain provides water for all life.

Q7. How does the rain become the voice of Earth?

Ans: The rain breathes fresh life into the dried-out Earth and falls in a rhythmic pattern. The soothing music created by softly dropping raindrops is Earth's way of expressing itself.

Poem 4: Childhood

By Markus Natten

Summary

In the poem, the poet wonders when he lost his childhood and the innocence he had. He became conscious that he no longer sees the world as he did earlier and he can sense the hypocrisy in people. He recalled many instances in his life when he could have lost his childhood.

Moments of Realization

He wondered if it was the day he ceased to be eleven or he realized that Hell and Heaven didn't exist in this world and no one could find them in the geography. Next, he talks about the possibility when he realized that adults are not what they seemed to be and they are hypocrites. They talk and preach of love but their actions don't say so.

Finding Individuality

Was it the day when he realized that his mind was his own and capable of producing his own thoughts? No one could own that and he is an individual with his particular personality. In the last stanza, he talks about the whereabouts of his childhood. He concludes that it had gone to some forgotten place and it can only be found in the innocent face of an infant.

Word Meanings

Ceased: come to an end **Preached:** talked or spoken **Infant:** newborn baby

Literary Devices

- **Rhyme Scheme:** ABBCCD

- **Refrain:** "When did my childhood go? Was that the day!" - repeated for emphasis
- **Antithesis:** "Hell and Heaven" - opposite words used together
- **Alliteration:** "The time", "My mind", "Whichever way", "Thoughts that"
- **Inversion:** "To use whichever way I choose" - reversed word order

Important Questions & Answers

Q1. What according to the poem is involved in the process of growing up?

Ans: Growing up involves losing one's childhood innocence. However, it brings advantages like greater comprehension, ability to reason and discriminate, and a sense of individuality.

Q2. What are the poet's feelings towards childhood?

Ans: The poet sees childhood as a crucial time of innocence and fantasy. The loss of childhood does not cause him regret or sadness, as it is a natural part of growing up.

Q3. Bring out the hypocrisy that the adults exhibit with regard to love.

Ans: Adults talk and preach about love, but their actions are quite different and rife with deception. They don't practice what they preach.

Q4. What did the poet notice about independent thinking?

Ans: The poet realized he was unique and had his own way of thinking. He was free to form his own opinions without being influenced by others.

Q5. According to Markus Natten, when does the child become an adult?

Ans: A child becomes an adult when they can live on their own, take care of their duties, and develop their own thought process to build their own beliefs.

Q6. Where has the poet's childhood gone?

Ans: The poet concludes that his childhood has gone to some forgotten place and can only be found in the innocent face of an infant.

Q7. "Childhood is an essential stage in the process of growing up, but it can't go on forever." Discuss.

Ans: Childhood is crucial for development but must give way to adolescence. The individual gains reasoning capacity, discrimination skills, and becomes an independent thinker.

Poem 5: Father to Son

By Elizabeth Jennings

Summary

The poem is about the agony of a father where he rants about the unsettling relationship with his son who is now a grown-up. He shares that although they had lived together in the same house for years, he doesn't understand him. He doesn't know anything about him and even if he tried to build up a relationship with him like the one when he was a small child, he was in vain.

The Communication Gap

He further says that even if his son looks like him, yet he doesn't know what he loves. He acknowledges the communication gap and lack of understanding between them and they speak like strangers. His son is in a different place which he cannot access due to the increasing gap. There is silence between them.

The Father's Longing

He is ready to forgive his prodigal son. He wants to accept him back to the house, the one which he always knew. He doesn't want his son to move around the world. He is longing to love him and would shape a new love from sorrow.

Word Meanings

Sown: do something which will bring a result

Prodigal: spending money freely; wasteful **Grief:** sorrow, sadness

Literary Devices

- **Simile:** "We speak like strangers" - comparing their relationship to strangers
- **Alliteration:** "The seed I spent or sown it where" (s sound), "Silence surrounds us"
- **Metaphor:** "The seed I spent or sown it where" - comparing raising a child to planting seeds; "The land is his and none of mine" - showing the distance between father and son

Important Questions & Answers

Q1. Why is the father unable to understand his son in 'Father to Son'?

Ans: Due to miscommunication and the generational divide, the father cannot understand his son. Though they lived together in the same house, they did not share any love or interests.

Q2. Why is the father unhappy with his son?

Ans: Even though they share a home, the father is upset because they never connect. They coexist like strangers and cannot understand one another. They have no common interests.

Q3. 'I would have him prodigal.' What does the father mean by this?

Ans: Like the prodigal son in the biblical tale, the father desires for his son to come back to him. The father would rejoice every time his son returned after a long absence.

Q4. What does the father feel about this stranger-like relationship with his son?

Ans: This stranger-like relationship bothers the father. He wants to change it since he is willing to accept his prodigal son. He is thrilled to begin sharing a home with him again.

Q5. What kind of relationship do the father and the son share? Why is it so?

Ans: The father and son have an estranged relationship. Despite living under the same roof, they behave as strangers. Their interests are completely unrelated because there is a communication gap between them.

Q6. What is the central idea of the poem "Father to Son"?

Ans: The poem centers on the tension between a father and son who have major communication gaps. Despite sharing a house, they are like strangers to one another. The father longs to rebuild their relationship.

Q7. The lesson reflects the realities of modern times. How do you feel about it?

Ans: The breakdown of the joint family system has caused grave issues for the elderly. The elderly need love, kindness, and respect, but the youth often view them as a

burden due to increasing materialism.

Quick Reference: Literary Devices

Literary Device	Definition	Example from Hornbill
Alliteration	Repetition of consonant sounds at the beginning of words	"Silence silences" (A Photograph)
Simile	Comparison using 'like' or 'as'	"Sleek as a lizard" (Laburnum Top)
Metaphor	Indirect comparison between two things	"I am the Poem of Earth" (Voice of Rain)
Personification	Giving human qualities to non-human things	"The whole tree trembles" (Laburnum Top)
Oxymoron	Contradictory terms used together	"Laboured ease" (A Photograph)
Hyperbole	Exaggerated statements	"Bottomless sea" (Voice of Rain)
Refrain	Repeated phrase or line	"When did my childhood go?" (Childhood)
Antithesis	Opposite words used together	"Hell and Heaven" (Childhood)

Authors and Their Works

Author	Work	Genre
Khushwant Singh	The Portrait of a Lady	Prose (Autobiographical)
Gordon Cook & Alan East	We're Not Afraid to Die...	Prose (Adventure)
A.R. Williams	Discovering Tut	Prose (History/Archaeology)
Jayant Narlikar	The Adventure	Prose (Science Fiction)
Nick Middleton	The Silk Road	Prose (Travelogue)
Shirley Toulson	A Photograph	Poetry (Nostalgic)
Ted Hughes	The Laburnum Top	Poetry (Nature)
Walt Whitman	The Voice of the Rain	Poetry (Nature)
Markus Natten	Childhood	Poetry (Reflective)
Elizabeth Jennings	Father to Son	Poetry (Relationship)

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This comprehensive study guide has been meticulously crafted by **Mohammad Faiz** to help Class 11 students excel in their English examinations.

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